Code of Conduct and Ethics

Document ID	HR-008
Department	Human Resources
Document type	Policy
Owner	General Counsel
Version	4.4
Status	APPROVED
Effective / last reviewed	2025-09-10
Audience	All employees
Related documents	HR-009, HR-014, SEC-006, OPS-003

Summary. Sets the ethical standards every Northstar Systems employee must follow, covering conflicts of interest, gifts and hospitality, anti-bribery, confidentiality, fair dealing, speaking up, non-retaliation and the consequences of breaching the Code of Conduct and Ethics.

SYNTHETIC DOCUMENT - Northstar Systems is a fictional company. This document exists for development, testing and demonstration only and is not real legal, employment, security or compliance advice.

1. Purpose and Scope

The Code of Conduct and Ethics sets out how everyone at Northstar Systems Private Limited is expected to behave towards colleagues, customers, vendors, regulators and the public. It describes the values that guide decisions when no specific rule exists and the minimum standards that apply when a rule does exist. Northstar sells enterprise software and technology services to business customers who trust us with their workflows, integrations and data. That trust is the most valuable thing the company owns, and it depends on honest and careful conduct by every employee.

The Code applies to all employees in Bands B1 to B7, whether based at Northstar Tower in Whitefield, Bengaluru, at the Powai office in Mumbai, or working remotely. It also applies to contractors, consultants, interns and temporary staff while they work for Northstar, and to members of the executive team, including the CEO, CFO, CTO, COO, CISO, Chief People Officer and General Counsel. Directors and executives have no exemption; they are held to the same standards and, because of their influence, are expected to model them.

The Code applies at work, at customer sites, at company events, on business travel, and in online or social settings where a person can reasonably be identified as a Northstar employee. It does not attempt to regulate private life that has no connection with the company.

Legal and regulatory references in this document are illustrative; to be verified by Legal before external use.

2. Our Core Principles

1 **Act with integrity.** Do the right thing even when nobody is watching and when it is inconvenient.
2 **Be honest and accurate.** Do not mislead customers, colleagues, auditors or regulators. Records, timesheets, expense claims and reports must be truthful.

3 **Respect people.** Treat every person with dignity. Harassment, discrimination and bullying are not tolerated; see the Anti-Harassment and POSH Complaint Procedure (HR-009).
4 **Protect what is entrusted to us.** This includes customer data, employee personal data, company property, intellectual property and money.
5 **Compete fairly.** Win business on the strength of products and service, not by improper payment or by disparaging competitors without basis.
6 **Speak up.** If something looks wrong, raise it. No one will be penalised for raising a concern in good faith.
7 **Take responsibility.** Managers answer for the conduct of their teams, and every employee answers for their own.

3. Roles and Responsibilities

Role	Responsibility
All employees	Read and follow the Code, complete annual acknowledgement, report suspected breaches
Managers	Model the standard, answer team questions, escalate concerns promptly, never retaliate
HR Business Partners	Advise on conduct questions and handle HR aspects of investigations
Employee Relations Manager	Runs conduct investigations and coordinates with the Disciplinary process in HR-014
General Counsel	Owns the Code, advises on legal risk, oversees investigations involving law, fraud or senior leaders
Chief People Officer	Hears appeals and decides on final disciplinary outcomes for Band B6 and above together with the General Counsel
Privacy Officer	Advises on use of personal data and decides on personal-data breach notifications

4. Conflicts of Interest

A conflict of interest arises when a personal interest, relationship or outside activity could influence, or appear to influence, an employee's judgement in their Northstar role. A conflict is not always wrongdoing; the wrong lies in failing to disclose it.

4.1 Common conflicts

- A relative or close personal friend works for, or owns, a vendor, customer or competitor that the employee deals with.
- The employee holds a financial interest in a vendor, customer or competitor, other than a small holding in a listed company through a mutual fund or a holding of less than 1% of a listed company's shares.
- The employee has a second job, consulting engagement, board seat or business that competes with Northstar, uses its time or equipment, or draws on its confidential information.
- The employee hires or supervises a relative or a person with whom they have a close personal relationship.
- The employee uses their Northstar position, information or contacts for personal gain.

4.2 Disclosure rule

An employee must disclose any actual or potential conflict in writing to their reporting manager and the HR Helpdesk before acting on the matter and in any event within 5 working days of becoming aware of it. HR records the disclosure, and the General Counsel decides, with the manager, whether the conflict is acceptable with safeguards, such as removing the employee from a vendor decision, or must be ended.

Employees who take part in vendor selection must also complete the conflict-of-interest declaration required by the Vendor Selection and Evaluation Procedure (OPS-003). An employee must not approve, evaluate or influence any procurement involving a person or business in which the employee or a close relative has an interest.

4.3 Relatives and personal relationships

Relatives, meaning spouse, partner, parent, child, sibling and in-laws, may work at Northstar, but one must not supervise, appoint, evaluate or approve the pay or expenses of the other. Where a reporting line is created accidentally, such as after a reorganisation, the employees must tell HR within 5 working days and the Chief People Officer will reassign the reporting line. A romantic relationship between a manager and a direct report, or anyone in the same reporting chain, must be disclosed to HR in the same way.

Example: A Procurement Executive in Bengaluru learns that the brother-in-law of a Band B5 engineer owns a company bidding for a laptop accessories contract worth INR 1,80,000. The engineer is on the evaluation panel. The engineer must disclose the relationship to the manager and HR Helpdesk and is removed from the panel. The quotation process continues with the remaining members, and the disclosure is filed in the engineer's record.

4.4 Outside work and activities

An employee may undertake paid outside work only with prior written approval from the department head and HR. Approval is not given if the work competes with Northstar, uses its time, equipment or confidential information, or creates a conflict with the employee's duties. Unpaid volunteering, teaching, open-source contributions and writing are generally allowed but must still not disclose confidential information. Contributions to open-source projects must also follow the open source licensing rules set by Engineering.

5. Gifts, Hospitality and Anti-Bribery

5.1 Principle

Northstar does not give or accept bribes, directly or through agents, in any form or in any country. A bribe is anything of value offered or accepted to influence a business decision or to gain an improper advantage. This applies to dealings with private parties as well as with government officials.

5.2 Gifts and hospitality received

Employees may accept modest gifts and hospitality that are occasional, offered openly, customary in the circumstances and unlikely to influence a decision. The following rules apply:

Item	Rule
Cash or cash equivalents, gift cards, vouchers	Must never be accepted
Gifts with a value up to INR 2,000	May be accepted; no approval required

Item	Rule
Gifts with a value above INR 2,000 and up to INR 5,000	Need reporting manager approval and must be recorded with the HR Helpdesk
Gifts above INR 5,000	Must be politely declined or, if refusal would cause offence, handed to HR and may be donated or used by the company
Meals and hospitality	May be accepted if reasonable, business-related and the host attends
Travel and accommodation paid by a vendor	Must be approved in advance by the department head and General Counsel

Gifts must never be accepted from a vendor during an active tender, quotation round or contract negotiation, regardless of value.

5.3 Gifts and hospitality given

Gifts and hospitality offered to customers or partners must be modest, transparent, business-related and compliant with the recipient's own rules. Any gift above INR 5,000 per person, or any hospitality for a government official or an employee of a public-sector customer, needs prior approval from the department head and General Counsel. Expenses must be recorded accurately in NorthPay as described in the Travel and Expense Reimbursement Policy (HR-004). Gifts must not be disguised as marketing spend or consulting fees.

5.4 Facilitation payments and third parties

Facilitation payments, meaning small unofficial payments to speed up routine government action, are prohibited. Northstar must not use an agent, reseller, consultant or other third party to do what it could not do itself. Any intermediary that deals with public officials on Northstar's behalf must be onboarded through NorthBuy and approved by the General Counsel.

Example: A reseller's representative sends a Customer Success Manager a hamper with a value of about INR 3,500 shortly after a renewal. Because the value is above INR 2,000, the CSM obtains manager approval and records the hamper with the HR Helpdesk. Had the reseller been in the middle of a pricing negotiation with Northstar, the gift would have to be declined regardless of its value.

6. Confidentiality and Protection of Information

Employees must protect Confidential and Restricted information, including customer production data, source code, product roadmaps, unreleased financial results, pricing, contract terms, employee personal data and credentials. The detailed classification and handling rules are owned by IT and Security. Core obligations under this Code are:

- Share information only with those who need it for their work and are authorised to receive it.
- Do not discuss non-public information in public places, on social media, or with family and friends.
- Do not use Restricted or Confidential information in external AI tools or personal email. Only tools on the Approved AI Tools list may be used, and no Confidential or Restricted data is permitted in external AI tools; see the Acceptable Use Policy (SEC-006).
- Return or delete company information when leaving the company. The duty of confidentiality continues after employment ends.

- Do not use information learned about a customer, a vendor or the company for personal investment or for the benefit of others (insider trading rules may apply; illustrative, to be verified by Legal).

An employee who is asked by a journalist, analyst, customer or regulator to comment on Northstar must refer the request to the Chief People Officer's office for media queries or to the General Counsel for regulatory matters. Employees must not give statements on behalf of the company unless authorised.

7. Fair Dealing, Honesty and Accuracy

7.1 Customers

Employees must describe products and services accurately. Sales and Customer Success staff must not promise features, delivery dates or service levels that Engineering has not confirmed. Customer-facing statements about uptime, service credits and support commitments must follow the approved Support Tier terms. Pricing exceptions must follow the Delegation of Authority and must never be agreed informally.

7.2 Vendors and partners

Selection must be based on merit, price, quality and security, not on personal relationships. Information on one bidder's quotation must never be disclosed to another. Vendors must be paid according to agreed terms and only against a valid purchase order.

7.3 Competitors

Employees must not obtain competitors' confidential information by improper means, such as asking a competitor's former employee to share it. They must not agree with a competitor on prices, markets or customers. Comparative statements about competitors must be factual and verifiable.

7.4 Records and reporting

All business records, including timesheets, expense claims, leave requests in NorthPeople, purchase requisitions in NorthBuy, support tickets in NorthAssist and financial entries, must be accurate and complete. Falsifying a record, backdating a document, altering a receipt, claiming an expense that did not happen or claiming for a personal expense as a business one is fraud and is treated as gross misconduct under HR-014. An employee who is asked by a manager to do any of these things should refuse and report the request.

7.5 Company property and resources

Company assets, from laptops and corporate cards to cloud accounts and intellectual property, are for business use. Limited personal use of devices is allowed if it does not breach policy. Employees must report lost or damaged assets within the timelines set out in the Asset Management policy and must not remove company property without authorisation. Intellectual property created in the course of employment belongs to Northstar.

8. Respectful Workplace

Northstar is committed to a workplace free from harassment, discrimination, bullying and victimisation. Discrimination on grounds such as gender, caste, religion, ethnicity, language, age, disability, marital status, sexual orientation or gender identity is not tolerated in hiring, pay,

promotion, assignment or termination. Sexual harassment is dealt with under the Anti-Harassment and POSH Complaint Procedure (HR-009), which sets out the role of the Internal Committee and the strict confidentiality rules. Other grievances, including bullying and unfair treatment, follow the Grievance and Disciplinary Procedure (HR-014).

Employees should expect and show professionalism in meetings, chats and email. Offensive jokes, comments about appearance, exclusion from work because of personal characteristics and shouting at colleagues are examples of behaviour that falls below the standard. Alcohol, illegal drugs and weapons are not permitted on company premises or at company events, other than alcohol served at an approved event by a licensed provider where moderation is expected.

Health and safety is part of conduct. Employees must follow safety rules at the offices, report hazards and accidents to Facilities and take part in emergency drills. Managers must not pressure employees to work in unsafe conditions.

9. Political Activity, Social Media and Public Conduct

Employees are free to take part in lawful political and civic activity in their own time and in their own name. They must not use company time, resources or the Northstar name for political purposes, and must not give the impression that their personal views are those of the company. Political donations must not be made on behalf of Northstar.

On social media, employees must not disclose Confidential or Restricted information, must not post screenshots of internal systems such as NorthPeople or NorthDesk, and must not attack colleagues, customers or competitors. An employee who identifies as a Northstar employee online should make clear that opinions are personal. Official company accounts are run only by authorised communication owners.

10. Speaking Up and Non-Retaliation

10.1 How to raise a concern

Anyone who suspects a breach of the Code, a law or any company policy should raise it promptly. Concerns may be raised through:

1 The reporting manager, or the manager's manager if the concern involves the manager.
2 The HR Business Partner or the HR Helpdesk at hr-helpdesk@northstar-systems.example.
3 The Employee Relations Manager for conduct matters.
4 The General Counsel for suspected fraud, bribery, legal breaches or concerns involving senior leaders.
5 The Security Desk (security@northstar-systems.example or ext. 5555) for security incidents.
6 The Internal Committee for sexual harassment, as set out in HR-009.

Reports may be made in person, in writing or by email. Reports about suspected fraud or bribery may be made anonymously to the General Counsel's office; anonymous reports are examined, but the investigators may be limited by the amount of detail provided.

10.2 What happens next

The person receiving a concern must acknowledge it within 2 working days and pass it to the Employee Relations Manager or General Counsel, as appropriate, without investigating on their own. The investigation is proportionate, fair and confidential. The person complained about is told

of the allegation and has a chance to respond. Information is shared only with those who need it. The person who raised the concern is told when the matter is closed, although details of any disciplinary action may be confidential.

10.3 Non-retaliation

Retaliation against anyone who raises a concern in good faith, or who helps in an investigation, is prohibited and is itself a serious breach of the Code. Retaliation includes dismissal, demotion, a poorer rating, unfair work allocation, exclusion, threats and harassment. An employee who believes they are suffering retaliation should report it to the HR Business Partner or the General Counsel. Raising a concern does not protect an employee from consequences of their own misconduct, and a report made knowingly falsely or in bad faith is itself a breach.

11. Acknowledgement and Training

All new joiners must read and acknowledge the Code in NorthPeople within 14 days of joining, as part of onboarding. Every employee must complete the Code of Conduct module in NorthLearn and re-acknowledge the Code each year. Managers should discuss the Code with their teams at least once a year. Failure to complete the acknowledgement by the deadline will be escalated to the manager and the HR Business Partner.

12. Breaches and Consequences

A breach of the Code may lead to disciplinary action under HR-014. The disciplinary ladder is verbal warning, written warning, final written warning and termination. The level of action depends on the seriousness, intent, impact, previous record and the employee's co-operation. The following may lead directly to termination without prior warnings:

- Fraud, theft, bribery or falsifying records.
- Sexual harassment or serious violence or threats.
- Deliberate disclosure of Restricted information.
- Retaliation against a person who raised a concern.
- Serious and wilful breach of security rules.

Where a show-cause notice is issued, the employee must reply within 3 working days. Appeals go to the Chief People Officer within 7 calendar days of the decision. Where conduct may amount to a criminal offence, the General Counsel decides whether to report it to authorities. Northstar may also seek to recover losses from the employee, subject to applicable law.

Managers who knew of a breach and failed to act may themselves face action.

13. Exceptions and Waivers

The Code is not waived for any employee. Where a specific provision may not reasonably apply in a given case, such as a gift tradition during a regional festival, the employee must ask the General Counsel before acting. A waiver for an executive must be approved by the CEO and General Counsel and recorded. Waivers are rare and written.

14. Frequently Asked Questions

May I accept a festival sweet box worth INR 800 from a vendor? Yes, if it is a modest gift offered openly and there is no live tender or negotiation. No approval is needed for gifts up to INR

2,000.

May I accept a vendor's invitation to a conference abroad with flights and hotel included? Not without prior approval from the department head and General Counsel. Travel and accommodation paid by a vendor are not covered by the small-gift allowance.

My cousin applied for a vacancy in another team. Is that a conflict? Disclose it to HR so that you are kept out of the hiring decision, and let the process run on merit.

A manager asked me to submit a receipt that was edited. What should I do? Do not submit it. Report the request to the HR Business Partner or General Counsel. You are protected against retaliation.

15. Related Documents

See the Anti-Harassment and POSH Complaint Procedure (HR-009) for sexual harassment complaints, the Grievance and Disciplinary Procedure (HR-014) for investigation and discipline steps, the Acceptable Use Policy (SEC-006) for information and AI tool use, the Vendor Selection and Evaluation Procedure (OPS-003) for vendor conflict declarations, and the Travel and Expense Reimbursement Policy (HR-004) for recording business hospitality.

16. Revision History

Version	Date	Change
4.2	2024-06-05	Added gift thresholds and relatives rule
4.3	2025-01-14	Added non-retaliation and anonymous reporting
4.4	2025-09-10	Clarified AI tool use, outside work and acknowledgement timing